my foot too early, and I'm off-balance and committed to playing the wrong line.

Sometimes the guys have odd bowling actions; so that if you watch the ball closely, your head tends to move with the action. Often a bowler will use the width of the crease, come wide over the wicket and angle the ball in. Part of the reason why they do this is to get you to follow them, so that you lose your balance a bit. And then they bowl a late swinging-away swinger that, now that you've moved across your stumps, either gets you plumb in front for an lbw, or gets you nicked behind.

A lot is made of getting your feet into the right position as a batter, but I haven't focused on that aspect too much. Again, for me, it's all about the position of my head and keeping my head still. In that bad trot I went through against the Aussies in 2005/06, mentioned earlier, I had a tough time dealing with Brett Lee because I was premeditating shots too often to try to deal with his pace. And he was probably at his quickest then – bowling at close to 160 km/h – and I played the short ball exceptionally badly in the Tests in Australia.

On some occasions Lee was bowling so fast that it felt as if he was coming in from 10 yards, not the actual 22-yard length of a cricket pitch. Because I was deciding on what shot I was going to hit before he had even bowled at me, my head would move as he released the ball, and consequently I'd be in trouble. What you don't want to do when facing a guy of Lee's pace is to get yourself on the wrong side of the ball. When you're off-balance instead of staying straight up, which allows you to either pull the ball or duck underneath it, you're unable to adjust. That's when you either get hit (which I did) or get out (again, which I did).

Bowlers have also discovered that when I'm playing tentatively, they have a better chance of getting me out. I have spoken to some of my Deccan Chargers teammates, whom I've previously played against in international cricket, and their general consensus is that when they get the ball to come back into me, chances are I'll be out either lbw or bowled. It isn't so much a technical flaw in my batting as it is playing tentatively early on, trying to predict what the bowler is going to bowl and not playing the ball on its merits.

Technically, my defence has always been pretty good – if you don't have a solid defence as an opening batsman in international cricket, you are never going to cut it. Any stuff written in the press about my defensive